

Deer velvet in S. Korea (1st quarter of 2026)

Reported on 10th of Apr 2026

1 Quarantine statistics of deer velvet from major export countries¹⁸

1.1 Dried velvet

Dried velvet (kg)								
Country	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026 (~Mar)
New Zealand	44,535	37,811	24,369	39,655	47,958	16,884	8,891	929
China	69,716	77,990	72,634	89,569	74,318	89,458	90,488	8,192
Russia	46,450	54,042	55,986	43,896	29,109	39,861	36,441	13,328
Hong Kong	17,828	13,701	22,372	23,835	12,597	4,347	3,699	900
Kazakhstan	701	2,354	1,428	2,097	1,095	413	1,058	
Total	179,782	185,931	176,842	199,086	165,095	150,974	140,588	23,350

1.2 Frozen velvet

Frozen velvet (kg)								
Country	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026 (~Mar)
New Zealand	99,113	77,477	91,874	116,584	116,292	76,939	94,225	33,482
China	10		2		2.6	443.8	1,356.5	
Russia								
Total	99,124	77,477	91,877	116,591	116,295	77,382	95,582	33,482

1.3 Rolling year

Dried velvet (kg)			Frozen velvet (kg)		
Country	Apr 2024 - Mar 2025	Apr 2025 - Mar 2026	Country	Apr 2024 - Mar 2025	Apr 2025 - Mar 2026
New Zealand	10,279	8,521	New Zealand	90,674	72,451
China	83,541	82,869	China	28.6	1,353

Russia	48,658	31,647	Russia		
Hong Kong	6,259	2,600	Hong Kong		0.1
Kazakhstan	413	1,058	Kazakhstan		
Australia	9	9.5	Australia		
USA	1	1.1	USA		
Others	1.4	0.3	Others		
Total	149,161	126,706	Total	90,703	73,804

2 Korean news

2.1 Yongbo CEO Kim inducted as Korea Grand Master in Deer velvet industry

According to **Yongbo Pharmaceutical**, the CEO **Kim Wol-jin** has been officially inducted as a **Korea Grand Master (Daehan Myeongin)** in the field of **Deer Velvet and Herbal Tea**. This prestigious recognition, awarded by the Korea Grand Master Association, honours individuals who have created significant social and industrial value through long-term craftsmanship and innovation. With over **40 years** of experience in the traditional health ingredients industry, Kim was specifically lauded for modernising traditional manufacturing processes through patented technologies. His key innovations include a patented **hair removal (geomo) process** for deer velvet antler that minimises contaminants and a **vacuum packaging technology** designed to enhance hygiene and freshness. These advancements address chronic issues in the industry such as quality variance and sanitation, ensuring that raw velvet antler maintains its inherent quality while meeting modern safety standards.



Seoul Economic TV, 2026-01-16¹

2.2 Advertorial by KGC about CheonNok on Lunar New Year (Holiday Sales Focus)

KGC Ginseng Corp has successfully positioned its Cheon-nok brand as **a high-value premium gift for the Lunar New Year**, contributing to its milestone of over **700 billion KRW in cumulative sales**. The brand highlights the nutritional value of its sourcing, particularly the inclusion of top jelly tips which are rich in minerals such as potassium, iron, and zinc.

Each product is developed using a synergy of 6-year-old Red Ginseng, deer velvet, and Angelica Gigas Root based on a patented formula. To ensure the highest quality, KGC directly oversees an 8-step management system for its New Zealand-sourced SAT-grade velvet. In conjunction with the 2026 holiday season, the company is running a promotional event from 23 January to 18 February,

¹ <https://www.sentv.co.kr/article/view/sentv202601160079>

offering benefits on its core lines and newer brands like Gidarrim Aloeswood and the blood sugar health brand GLPro.



Dong-A Ilbo, 2026-01-23²

2.3 Deer velvet tea on the TV show

A television personality Jun Hyun-mu was diagnosed with Qi Deficiency (Gi-heo-jeung) during a health consultation on the JTBC programme *Honja-neun Mot-hae*. The attending Oriental medical doctor, Kim Yong-jin, noted that Jun's pulse indicated extreme exhaustion and a weakened immune system due to an excessive workload and lack of rest. As a person with the **Tae-eum-in body type** (one of the four Sasang constitutions), **Jun was prescribed Deer Velvet Tea (Nok-yong-cha) to recover his vitality.**

According to the World Health Organization (WHO) and studies in the Journal of Traditional Chinese Medicine, Qi Deficiency is defined as a state where the body's vital energy is insufficient, leading to chronic fatigue, shortness of breath, and reduced metabolic function. Experts like Dr Kim So-hyeong suggest that managing this condition requires a balanced lifestyle, avoiding overexertion, and using medicinal herbs such as Ginseng, Astragalus Root (Hwang-gi), and Deer Velvet to warm the body and replenish energy.



The Korea Economic Daily, 2026-01-28³

2.4 Advertorial by KGC about CheonNok (Marketing focus)

Since its launch in 2014, KGC JungKwanJang's premium brand **Cheon-nok has achieved cumulative sales exceeding 700 billion KRW.** To further strengthen its market presence, the company has appointed actor Lee Jin-uk as its official model for a new advertising campaign centred on the theme Intensity of Vitality. The brand emphasizes its **use of 100% SAT-grade deer velvet guaranteed by the New Zealand government**, incorporating the whole stick including the rare top jelly tips. Quality is maintained through a strictly managed

² <https://www.donga.com/news/Economy/article/all/20260122/133203975/2>

³ <https://www.hankyung.com/amp/2026012870987>

8-step production and distribution process that spans from farm selection to direct air transport.

Additionally, the products feature a patented **Energy Strengthening Composition** that blends deer velvet with Angelica Gigas Root to specifically target a loss of vitality. The lineup has also expanded to include life-cycle specific options like Cheon-nok Women, Cheon-nok Senior, and safety-verified Cheon-nok Growing for children.



Asia Business Daily, 2026-01-29⁴

2.5 Advertorial by Yuhan Care about HENKIV

The Ministry of Food and Drug Safety (MFDS) has recently recognised "Velvet Antler Enzyme Hydrolysis Extract (HENKIV®)" as a functional ingredient for improving immune function. This extract is sourced from the deer velvet, non-calcified antlers of Sika deer, Elk, or Red deer, and must be standardised to contain **a minimum of 0.9mg/g of Uracil and 1.2mg/g of Hypoxanthine**. In a clinical trial involving 106 adults aged 40 to 70, a daily dose of 480mg taken over eight weeks was found to significantly increase Natural Killer (NK) cell activity and levels of the cytokine interferon-gamma (IFN-γ). However, the extract should be avoided by infants, children, and pregnant or breastfeeding women. It is also contraindicated for individuals with hormone-sensitive conditions, such as breast or uterine cancer, due to its oestrogen-like activity, and athletes are warned that its Insulin-like Growth Factor-1 (IGF-1) content may impact doping results.



KPA (Korea Pharmaceutical Association) News, 2026-02-14⁵

2.6 The levy of Korean deer farm industry

The committee for the levy of Korean deer farm is distributing information to deer farmers to promote the fund as "minimum insurance" for the industry. **The South Korean government provides a 50% subsidy to match funds** used for education, promotion, and research programmes. For the year 2026, the government subsidy for the deer industry is set at 70 million KRW, a decrease from the 80 million KRW allocated in 2025 (of which only 59 million KRW was actually provided due to **insufficient fund collection by farmers**).

In comparison, the total government subsidy for all livestock levy funds in 2026 is 22,596 million KRW, with Beef Cattle (Hanwoo) receiving the largest share of 9,161 million KRW.

Furthermore, the committee finalised a revised budget of **141.8 million KRW**

⁴ <https://view.asiae.co.kr/article/2026012810331575698>

⁵ <https://www.kpanews.co.kr/news/articleView.html?idxno=529454>

on 27 January 2026, reducing it from the initial 162 million KRW proposal following government recommendations.



The Korea Deer Times, 2026-02-10

2.7 Deer Velvet with red ginseng remains resilient amid declining red ginseng demand

General search interest for red ginseng in South Korea is experiencing a decline, while Deer Velvet -infused Red Ginseng (Nok-yong-hong-sam) has emerged as the sole growth category. Data from Consumer Insight indicates that **overall red ginseng searches during the 2026 Lunar New Year decreased by 43.7% compared to the previous year**, falling to approximately 1.13 million queries. In contrast, **interest in Deer Velvet -infused Red Ginseng increased by 48% during the same period**, with its share of total red ginseng searches rising to 8.9%. Notably, KGC Ginseng Corp's premium product, **Cheon-nok-ton, entered the top 10 individual product searches for the first time**, driven by aggressive marketing and its positioning as a high-tier premium alternative. This trend suggests a consumer shift toward higher-value functional ingredients as the traditional red ginseng market—once the top-selling health functional food before being overtaken by vitamins and minerals in 2024—reaches saturation. The Korea Economic Daily, 2026-03-24⁶

2.8 K-Beauty, from retail products to high-value clinical tourism

**Last quarter article but included for the market context.*

K-Beauty's global rise is rooted not in products, but in culture. South Korean society has long placed an extraordinary value on appearance—a standard shaped by decades of television stars embodying flawless, youthful, radiant skin. This cultural foundation created the demand, the expertise, and ultimately the industry. Product sales—the sheet masks, serums, and viral retail hauls like White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt's CJ Olive Young spree during the 2025 APEC summit—are what the world sees.

But they are not where the real economic weight lies. That sits firmly in South Korea's clinical and medical tourism industry. In 2024, South Korea welcomed a record **1.17 million foreign medical tourists—nearly double the previous year—with dermatology alone accounting for 56.6% of all visits**, totalling 705,000 patients seeking treatments that no hand cream can replicate.

In the same year, South Korea surpassed France for the first time to become the leading cosmetics exporter to the **United States**, with beauty product exports reaching **\$1.7 billion and capturing 22.4% of the entire US import market**. In Japan, Korean cosmetics held a 28.8% market share—outpacing France's 25.1%—for the third consecutive year.

The author, a dermatologist with 20+ years of experience, argues K-beauty's rise is no accident and points to three key reasons:

① **Science & Innovation** — Ingredients like snail mucin, Centella asiatica, and propolis have been scientifically validated. Centella's wound-healing and anti-

⁶ <https://www.hankyung.com/article/202603241697a>

inflammatory effects are backed by clinical studies. fnnews Korea also moves faster than Western countries in adopting new aesthetic treatments safely.

② **System & Speed** — Korea's high population density and world-class internet infrastructure mean new products get real-time consumer feedback via social media, and brands can release improved versions within 1–2 months fnnews — a pace impossible in the US or Europe. The Gangnam district essentially functions as a global beauty laboratory.

③ **Content & Emotional Appeal** — K-beauty sells not just products but "stories." Concepts like "glass skin" and "honey skin" spread globally through YouTube and TikTok, and K-drama stars serve as living advertisements.



Financial News, 2025-11-20⁷

2.9 Nine essential ingredients tailored for specific skin concerns amid the K-beauty boom

the global success of K-Beauty is driven by a diverse range of scientifically proven ingredients, though dermatologists advise selecting them based on specific skin concerns rather than following general trends. The article identifies nine essential ingredients currently leading the market:

1. **Ginseng**: Contains **ginsenosides that act as antioxidants to neutralise oxidative stress**, boost collagen, and improve the appearance of dull skin.
2. **Snail mucin**: Rich in **glycoproteins and hyaluronic-like molecules**, it provides deep hydration and promotes tissue regeneration, making it ideal for dry or irritated skin.
3. **Fermented** ingredients: Utilises **probiotics and rice water** to brighten the complexion, strengthen the skin barrier, and balance the microbiome without irritation.
4. **Niacinamide: A form of Vitamin B3** that regulates sebum production, reduces inflammation, and minimises the appearance of pores and hyperpigmentation.
5. **Centella asiatica**: Frequently used for its ability to **calm redness, soothe sensitive skin**, and stimulate fibroblast **activity for collagen** synthesis.
6. **PDRN** (polydeoxyribonucleotide): Extracted from **salmon DNA**, this ingredient activates cellular receptors to **trigger collagen** production, **aiding recovery from inflammation or cosmetic procedures**.
7. **Peptides: Amino acid chains** that signal the skin to produce structural proteins like elastin and collagen; these are considered safe and effective for all skin types.
8. **Tranexamic acid**: Acts as a brightening agent by **managing melanin pathways** to reduce **sun damage, age spots**, and **uneven skin tone**.
9. **Propolis**: Offers **antibacterial and anti-inflammatory** benefits that suppress **acne-causing bacteria** and facilitate overall skin recovery.

Hidoc, 2026-04-08⁸

⁷ <https://www.fnnews.com/news/202511201834559490>

⁸ <https://news.hidoc.co.kr/news/articleView.html?idxno=60813>

3 News related with product launching

3.1 Kwangdong Geongangwon - Deer Velvet Sturgeon

Brand <Product name>	Kwangdong Geobukwon < Deer Vevlet Sturgeon >		
Company/Manufacturer	Kwangdong Geongangwon		
Volume and type	2.7l (90ml x 30 pouches)	Price in KRW	270,000
Product category	Extract food	Other ingredients	Sturgeon 25%, Red ginseng
Deer velvet %	unspecified	Origin of velvet	New Zealand

Kwangdong Pharmaceutical's newly established **subsidiary**, Kwangdong Geongangwon, has launched a premium health tonic brand called Kwangdong Geobukwon. The brand's debut features two products: Aloeswood Black Goat and **Deer Velvet Sturgeon**, both of which use an "order-made" production system where items are manufactured **only after an order is placed** to ensure freshness. These tonics are formulated with 13 traditional ingredients, including 6-year-old Korean Red Ginseng. Notably, the Deer Velvet Sturgeon variant incorporates Kwangdong's patented "Angelica Gigas, Deer Velvet, and Astragalus Root **Composite Extract Powder**." To enhance consumer trust, the company provides transparency by sharing photos and videos of the manufacturing process with customers. The products are scheduled for official release on 1 April 2026, following a pre-order period.



The Financial News 2026-03-25⁹

Appendix I. Spreadsheets are supplied separately

Import statistics. Korean import statistics for deer velvet.xlsx	Biosecurity pass recording not HS Code based trade records by export country . Source is Animal and Plant Quarantine Agency (농림축산검역본부 ¹⁰)
Food imports list. Korean food imports list for deer velvet.xlsx	Number of trade recording by food importers and products they imported. No volume or price of each trade but counting trade events. No data for imports for pharmaceutical purpose. Source is Imported Food Information Maru website (수입식품정보마루 ¹¹)
Food products. Deer velvet food products in	Accumulated food product list over recent years. Based on various news article about product launching mostly supplied originally by the brand owner as a press release

⁹ <https://www.fnnews.com/news/202603250907319448>

¹⁰ <http://eminwon.qia.go.kr/statistics/> (품목-국가별 수출입현황)

¹¹ <https://impfood.mfds.go.kr/CFCCC01F01>

Korea.xlsx

activity.

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